

World History Ch. 3: Ancient Egypt and the Old Kingdom

The gift of the Nile

The Greek historian Herodotus called Egypt "the gift of the Nile," and the description fits. Almost no rain falls across most of the country, yet a green ribbon of farmland follows the river for hundreds of miles. Every summer the Nile flooded its banks and spread water across the valley floor. When the water drew back it left a layer of rich black silt behind. Egyptians called their fertile land Kemet, the black land, and the desert beyond it Deshret, the red land.

The farming year followed the river in three seasons. Akhet was the season of the flood, when the fields lay under water. Peret was the growing season, when farmers planted wheat and barley in the damp silt. Shemu was the harvest season, when the crops were cut and stored before the next flood. Farmers dug canals and basins to trap floodwater and carry it to fields that lay farther from the river.

The height of the flood decided whether Egypt ate well. Officials measured the rising water with a Nilometer, a staircase or shaft marked in cubits. A low flood meant dry fields, poor harvests and hunger, while a flood that rose too high could sweep away villages. Because the size of the harvest could be predicted from the flood, the Nilometer readings were also used to set taxes.

Pharaoh, society and writing

At the top of Egyptian society stood the pharaoh, who was believed to be a god on earth. The pharaoh's duty was to keep ma'at, the order and balance of the world, by governing the land and honoring the gods. Beneath the pharaoh, the vizier ran the government, collected taxes and served as chief judge. Nobles and priests formed the next level, followed by scribes, who kept the records that held the kingdom together.

Below them were skilled artisans and traders, such as stone carvers, painters and merchants. Farmers made up the large majority of the population. Most people were born into their place, but a talented boy who learned to read and write could rise by becoming a scribe. Enslaved people existed, usually prisoners of war, but they were a small part of the population.

Scribes trained for years to master hieroglyphs, a writing system with more than 700 signs. Some signs are logograms that stand for a whole word, while others are phonograms that stand for sounds. The name of a pharaoh was written inside an oval ring called a cartouche. Everyday records were written in ink on papyrus, a paper made from reeds that grew along the Nile. The Rosetta Stone, found in 1799, carries the same decree in hieroglyphs, demotic and Greek, and it allowed Jean-Francois Champollion to decipher hieroglyphs in 1822.

Building for eternity

The Old Kingdom, from about 2686 to 2181 BCE, is known as the Age of the Pyramids. The largest, the Great Pyramid of Giza, was built for the pharaoh Khufu around 2560 BCE. It contains about 2.3 million stone blocks and originally rose 146 meters, and it remained the tallest human-made structure on Earth for about 3,800 years. Khufu's vizier, Hemiunu, is believed to have overseen the work.

The pyramids were not built by slaves. Archaeologists have found a workers' village near the pyramids with bakeries, breweries and sleeping halls. Paid workers were organized into crews and received rations of bread and beer, and some were treated for injuries by doctors. Workers who died on the job were buried in tombs close to the pyramid, an honor no slave would have received. Many laborers were farmers who worked on the pyramid during the flood season, when their fields were under water.

Most of the stone was quarried at Giza itself. Workers cut limestone blocks with copper tools, dragged them on wooden sledges and pulled them up ramps of mud brick and rubble. Pouring water on the sand in front of a sledge made it much easier to drag. Fine white limestone from Tura was used for the smooth outer casing, and heavy granite for the king's burial chamber was floated down the Nile from Aswan.

Death and the afterlife

Egyptians believed that life continued after death, but only if the body was preserved. Embalmers turned the body into a mummy in a process that took about 70 days. First they removed the internal organs and placed them in canopic jars, but they left the heart in the body because it was thought to be the seat of thought. Next they covered the body with natron, a natural salt, for about 40 days to dry it out. Finally they wrapped it in layers of linen with protective amulets and placed it in a coffin.

The Book of the Dead was a collection of spells to guide the dead through the underworld. In the Hall of Two Truths the heart was weighed against the feather of Ma'at. A heart heavy with wrongdoing was eaten by the monster Ammit, while a heart as light as the feather let the soul pass on to the afterlife.

Egyptians worshipped many gods, each with a role. Ra was the sun god who sailed across the sky each day. Osiris ruled the afterlife and judged the dead. Isis was the goddess of magic and protection. Anubis, shown with the head of a jackal, watched over embalming and guided souls. Horus, the falcon-headed sky god, was the protector of kingship, and Thoth, shown with the head of an ibis, was the god of writing and wisdom.